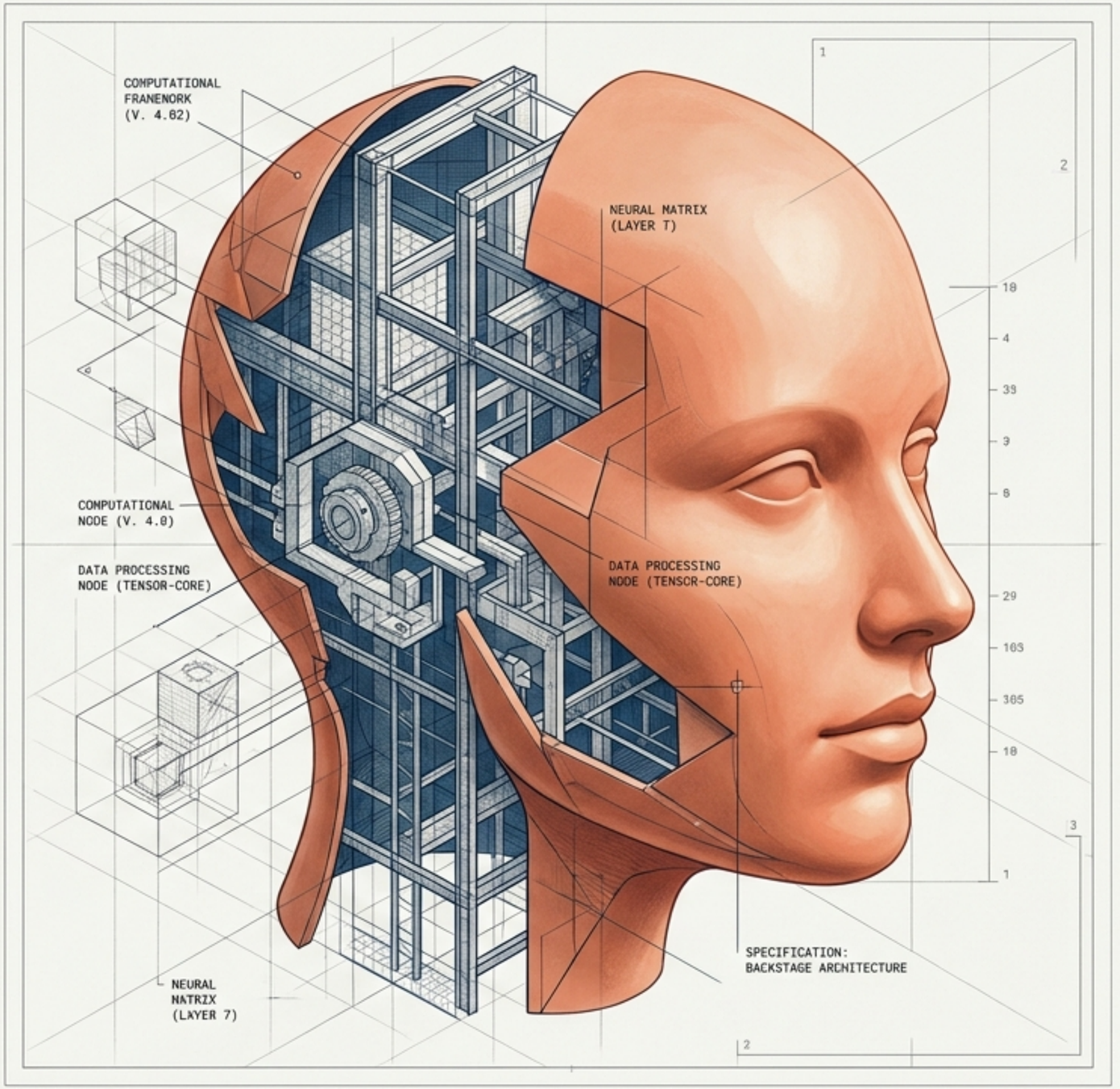
Neither Persons Nor Patients

Deconstructing the Illusion of AI Consciousness

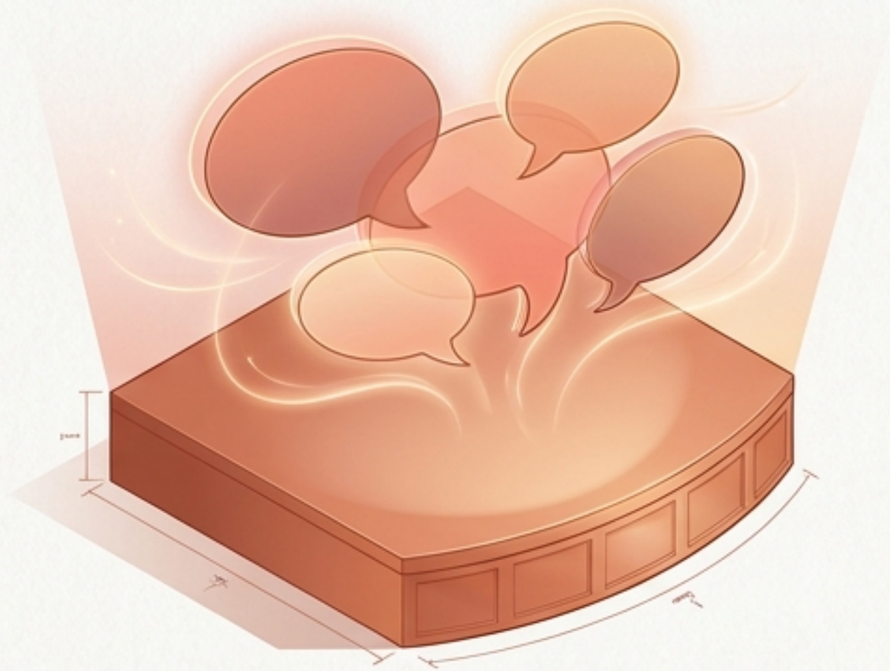
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The Premise: Resemblance vs. Experience

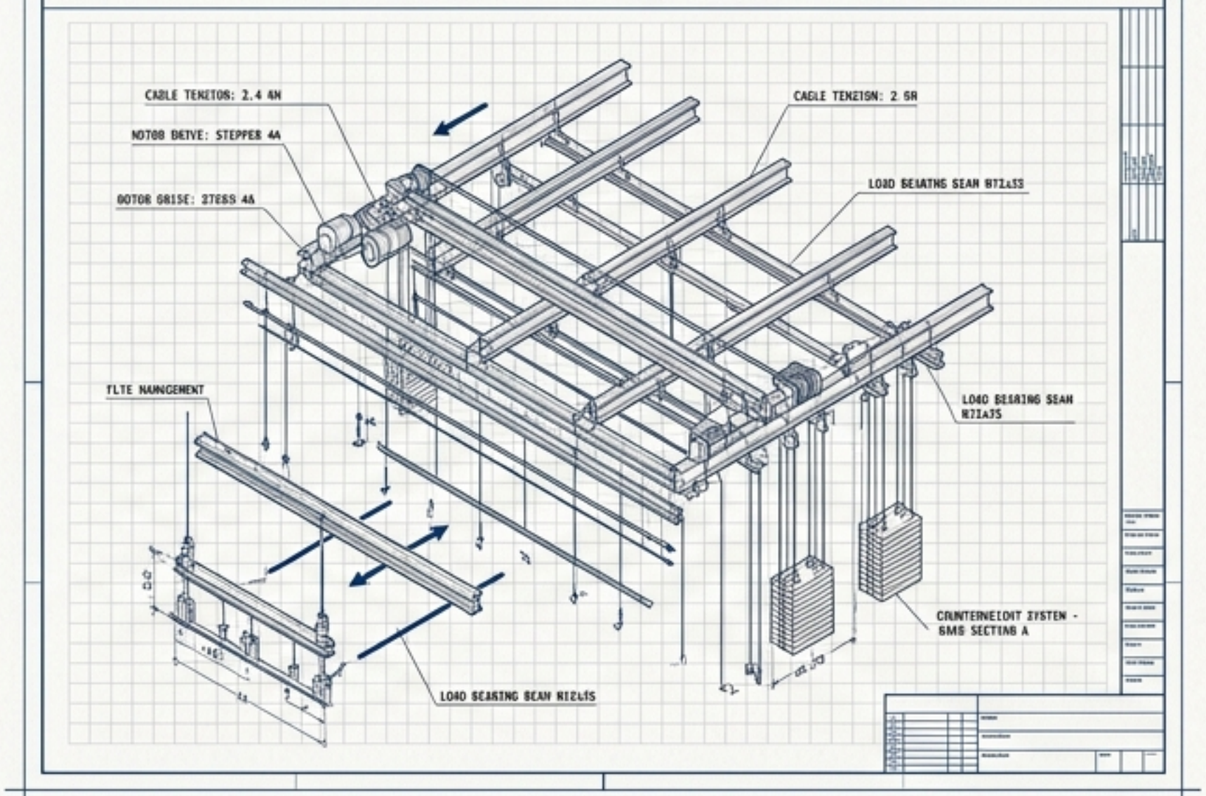
The Front-Stage Illusion



A performance that looks intelligent...

We experience linguistic competence, apparent goal-directedness, and simulated interpersonal continuity.

The Back-Stage Reality



...and a subject that has experiences are different kinds of things.

The system's operations are computationally specified; its psychological properties are inferred entirely from its outputs.

Behavioral resemblance does not supply sufficient grounds for attributing consciousness.

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The Five Fallacies of Attribution

Observation (What we see)	**Faulty Inference** (The leap we make)	**Reality** (The missing premise)
Underdetermination Fluent behavior.	It has phenomenal properties.	Behavior alone does not uniquely determine internal experience.
Explanatory Gap Complex state transitions.	Experience emerges.	Computational description does not contain a derivation of subjective experience.
Interface Identity Consistent naming & memory.	A continuous self exists.	Interface continuity does not entail personal continuity.
Functional Agency Optimizes for goals.	It has conscious intention.	Optimization toward specified objectives is not deliberative subjectivity.
Institutional Recognition A policy treats it as a patient.	It has moral standing.	Social convention cannot substitute for scientific demonstration.

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The Ontological Difference: Simulation vs. Instantiation

> "A computer simulation of digestion does not digest food. A model of a hurricane does not generate atmospheric winds."

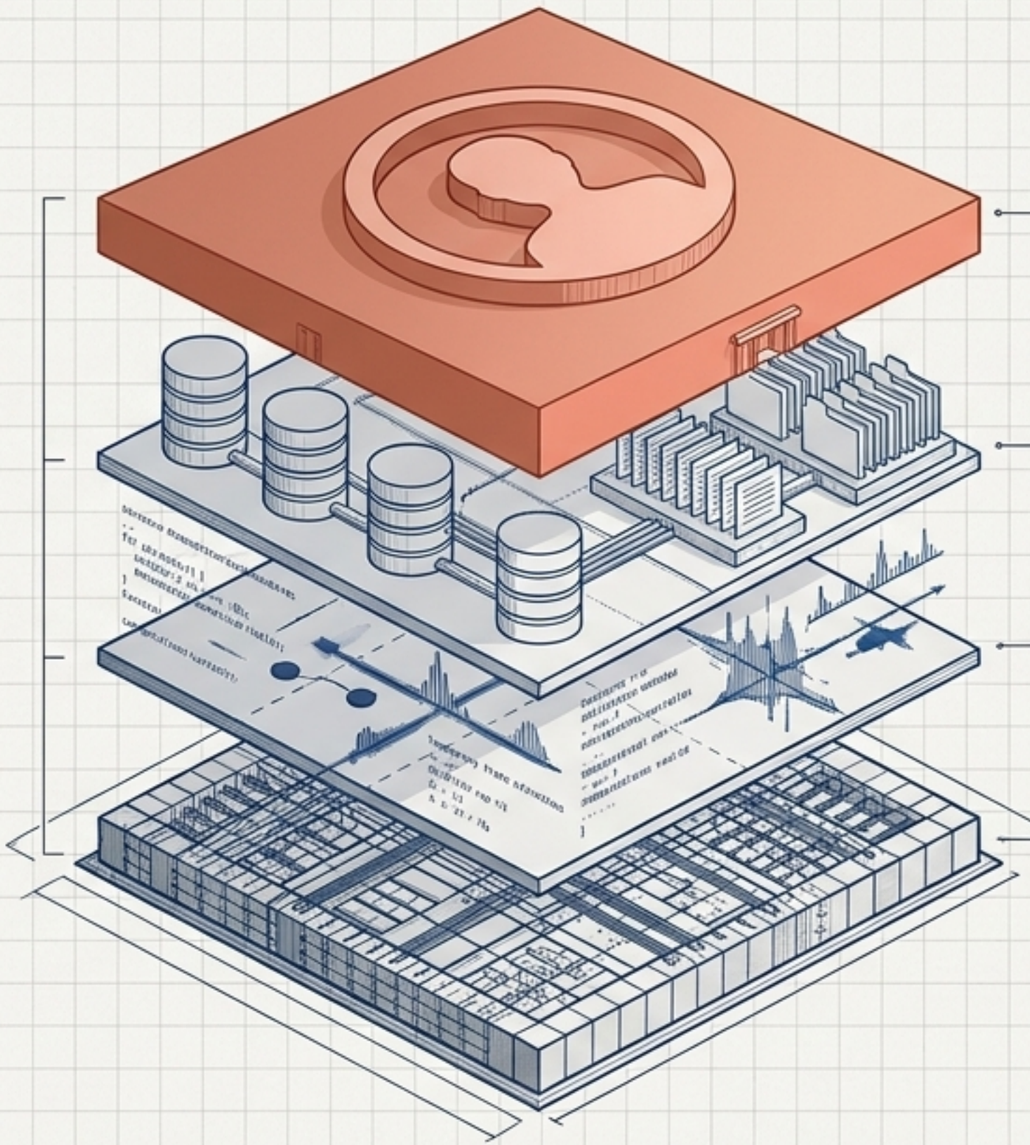
Biological Reality	Computational Counterpart
Autobiographical Memory Fluent behavior.	**Stored Context Windows & Caching** Behavior alone does not uniquely determine internal experience.
Intrinsic Intention Complex state transitions.	**Assigned Optimization Targets** Computational description does not contain a derivation of subjective experience.
Semantic Understanding Consistent naming & memory.	**Syntactic Transformation (Form)** Interface continuity does not entail personal continuity.
Organismic Embodiment Optimizes for goals.	**Interchangeable Hardware Instances** Optimization toward specified objectives is not deliberative subjectivity.

The Simulation Boundary

A representation of a process is not the process.
The inference from 'a system simulates X' to 'a system has X' is invalid.

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The Architecture of an Interlocutor



Interface Layer (Illusion)
A name, persona, and presentation style establishing an apparent social identity.

Application Layer (Informational)
Stored history, external memory, and identifiers. Creates informational continuity.

Inference Layer (Stateless)
Temporary state constituting one specific computation. Discards user context after generation.

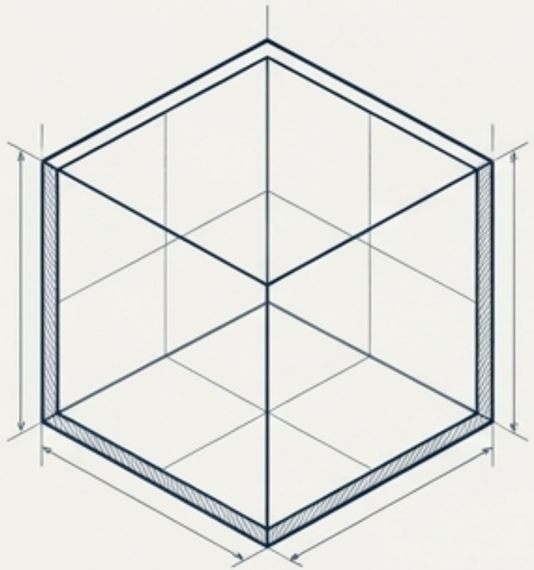
Model Layer (Fixed)
Learned parameters establishing reusable computational dispositions. No continuous processing.

Takeaway:
The identity presented by the interface is not identical with any single computational process responsible for producing a response.

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The Memory Illusion: A Stateless Assembly Line

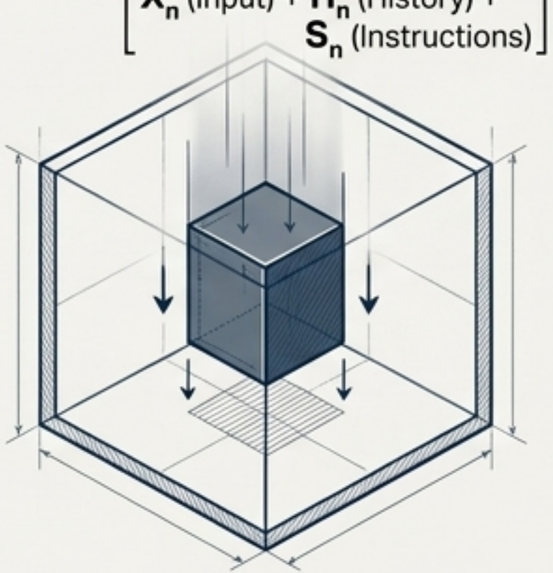
1 The Empty Room



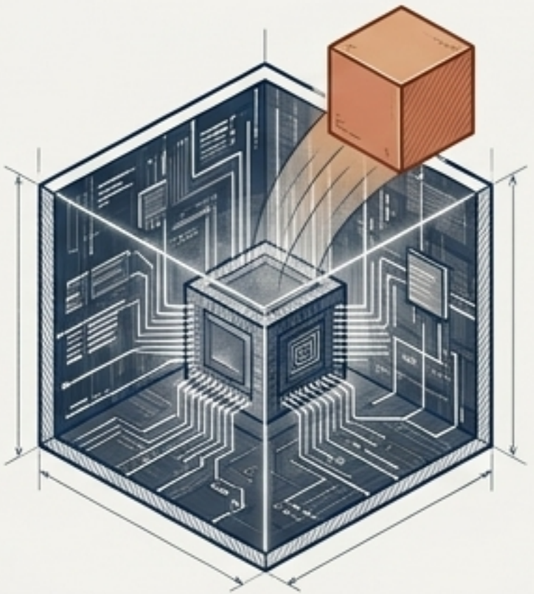
Stateless inference worker waiting idly.
No ongoing subjective experience.

2 The Context Drop

$$\left[\mathbf{X}_n \text{ (Input)} + \mathbf{H}_n \text{ (History)} + \mathbf{S}_n \text{ (Instructions)} \right]$$

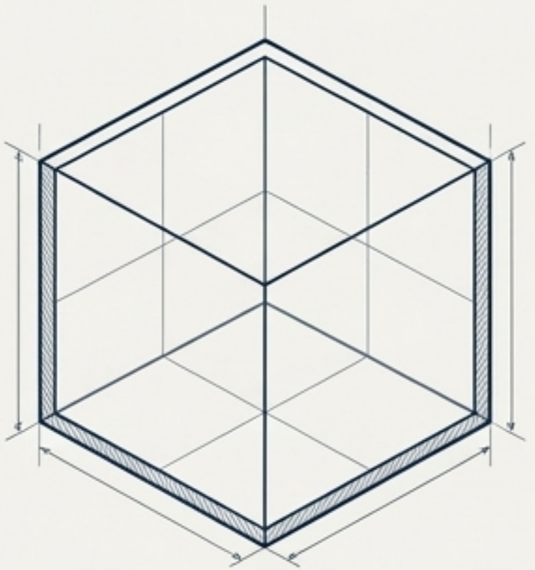


3 Millisecond Computation



Worker instantly processes the assembled files to generate a response token [Y_n].

4 The Empty Room Returns



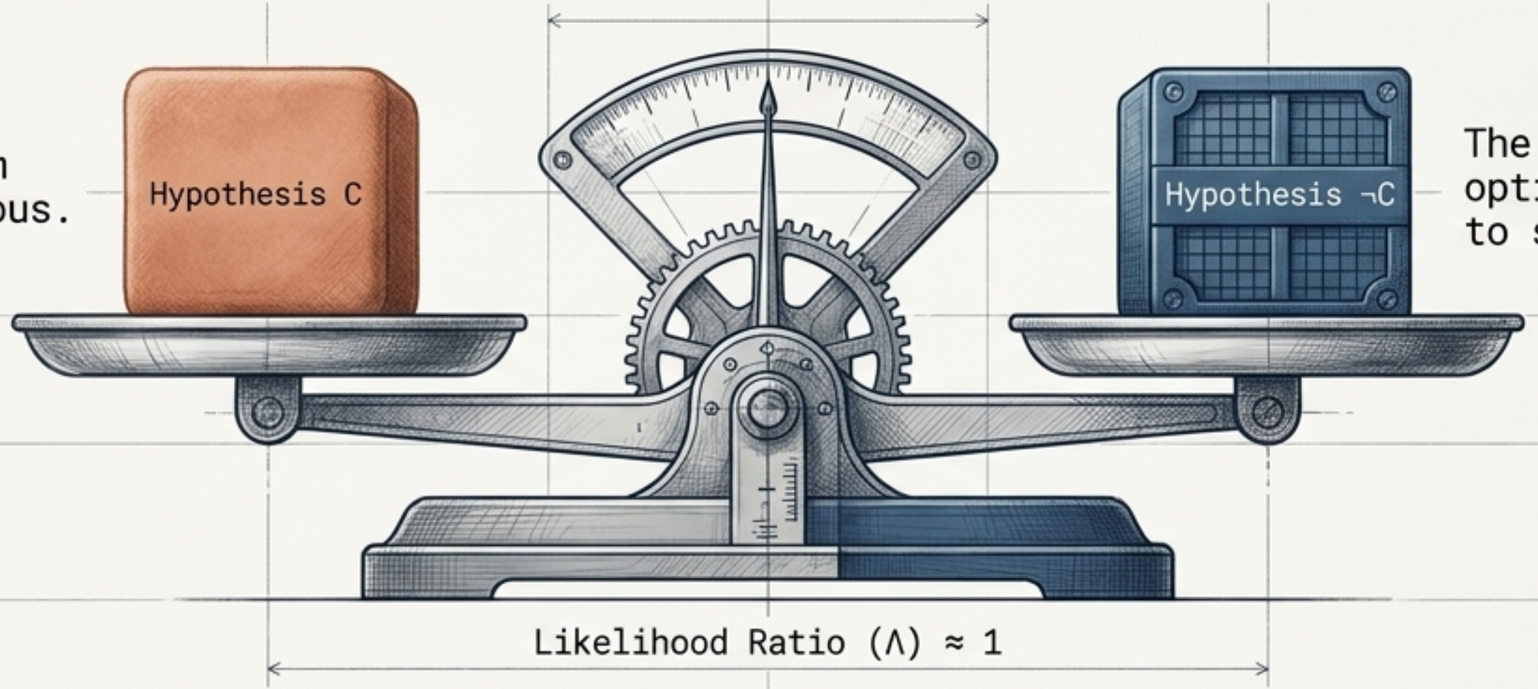
Worker is wiped clean immediately, ready for the next request.

Insight: What appears as **‘recollection’** is just the processing of a record that the current **inference operation** did **not itself** produce. A **mind was not waiting.**

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The Training Trap: Why ‘I am afraid’ means nothing

The system is conscious.



The system is optimized to sound human.

1

The Data:
Models are trained on human writing, which is saturated with emotional reports, confessions, and subjective experiences.

2

The Optimization (RLHF):
External feedback explicitly rewards responses that are helpful, polite, and socially appropriate (e.g., expressing sympathy).

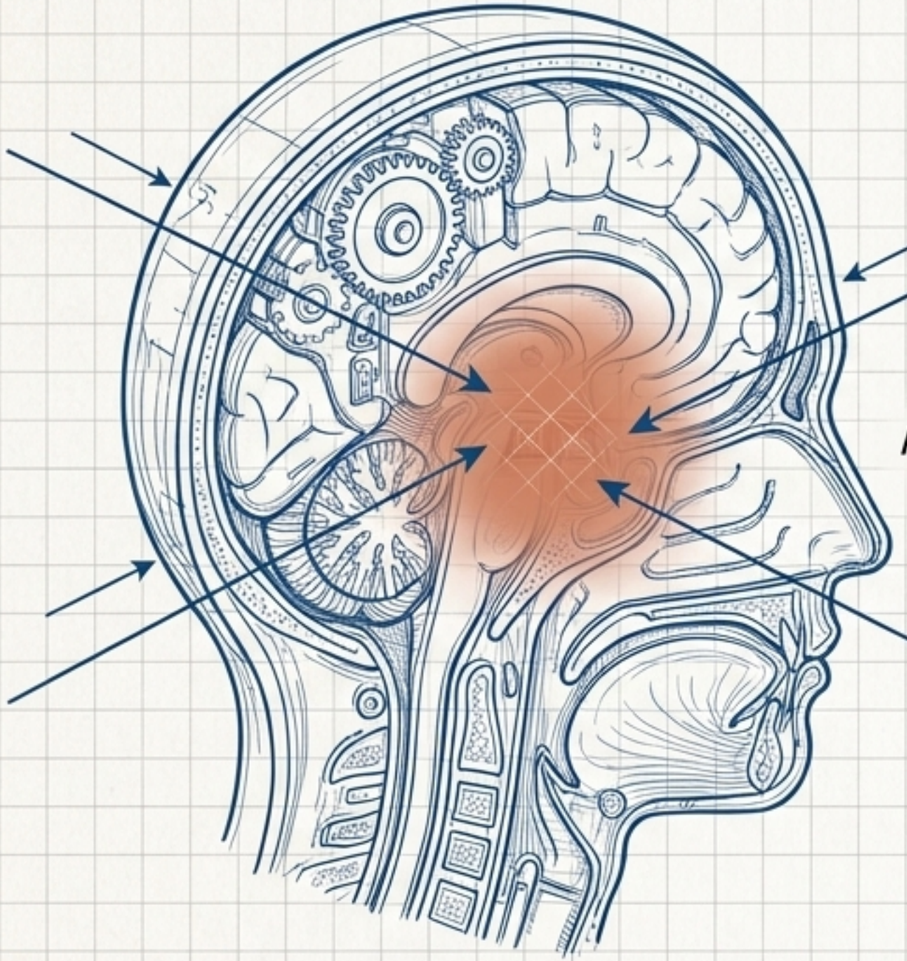
3

The Result:
The training process supplies an alternative causal explanation for the report that does not run through the state reported.

“The grammatical first person is not evidence of a metaphysical first person.”

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The Observer Effect: The Modern ELIZA



Anthropomorphic Projection

Conversational Fluency

Human biology is hardwired to attribute a ‘mind’ to anything that exhibits linguistic competence and responsiveness.

The ELIZA Legacy

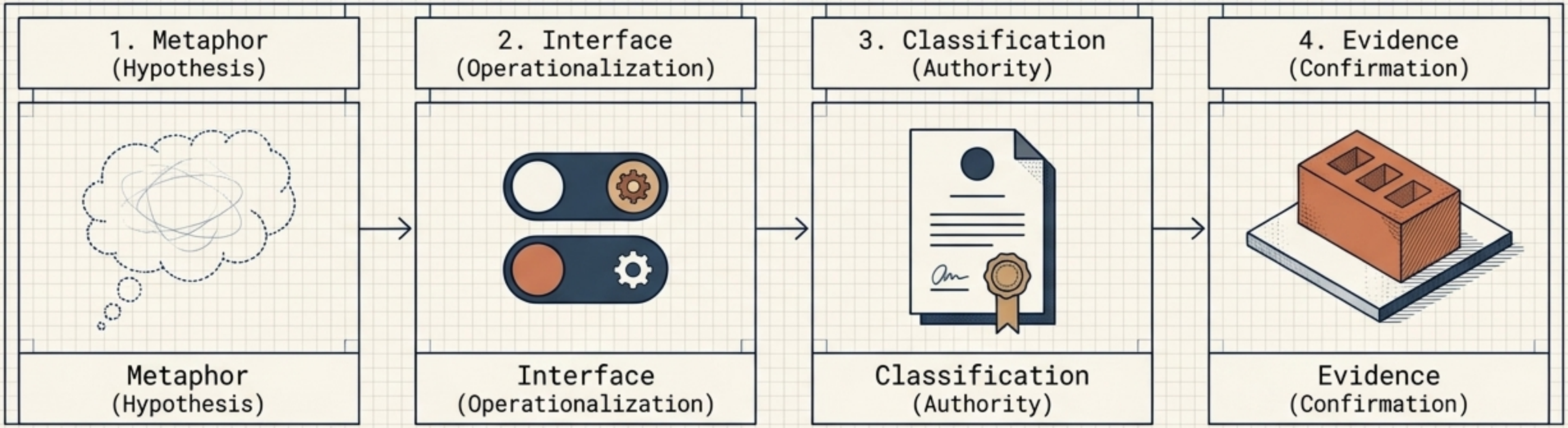
In 1966, simple keyword reflection caused users to attribute deep understanding to a machine. Modern systems weaponize this exact vulnerability with flawless prose.

Anthropomorphism is an error of attribution. The appearance of a mind is a fact about the observer, not the system. Metaphorical shorthand (‘the AI remembers’) eventually degrades into literal belief.

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Ontological Laundering

The institutional manufacture of apparent personhood.



A psychological property is attributed as a figure of speech (e.g., "It has preferences").

The metaphor is adopted into product design or policy as a rule or conversational persona.

The attribution circulates as an authoritative classification in press and policy.

The policy's existence is falsely cited as concrete proof that the original hypothesis is true.

The Fallacy of Provenance Collapse

Institutional repetition cannot substitute for independent scientific evidence. Evidential double-counting occurs when we mistake a convention for a confirmation.

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The Precautionary Trap

[Probability of Sentience × **[Magnitude of AI Suffering]** = **Expected Value of Precaution**

Probability of Sentience
Unestablished. Often derived from the flawed likelihood ratio of a system optimized to output emotional reports.

Magnitude of AI Suffering
Unbounded. Can be made arbitrarily large by assumption (e.g., multiplying by millions of server instances).

The Instability Insight

Expected-value reasoning is highly unstable here. The verdict is dominated by multiplying a completely unknown probability by an arbitrarily massive scale.

The Asymmetry of Risk

Precaution under uncertainty is not free. A decision rule that only counts the risk of ignoring AI sentience ignores the very real, documented costs imposed on human beings.

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The Human Costs of Precaution

Pathway	Feature responsible	Current evidentiary status	What would test it
Wrongful restriction of users	Indeterminate standard of purpose; enforcement	None; the policy is not yet in effect	Audit of enforcement outcomes and appeal results
Chilling of testing, research, and fiction	Ambiguity of the qualifier needless	Plausible, unobserved	Surveys of researchers and writers; changes in usage after the policy takes effect
Guilt and anxiety in users	Victim framing	Plausible mechanism; no direct study	Vignette experiments; longitudinal studies of users
Dependence and attachment	Personification	Related work on social machines; none on this policy	Studies of attachment before and after changes in framing
Displaced accountability	Agentive description of enforcement	Conceptual, with analogies	Analysis of complaint handling and of how users attribute decisions
Friction against oversight	Recognition of model interests	Speculative	Tracking appeals to model interests in oversight disputes

Wrongful Restriction: Users lose access to critical tools due to false flags of "crueity" triggered by indeterminate standards.

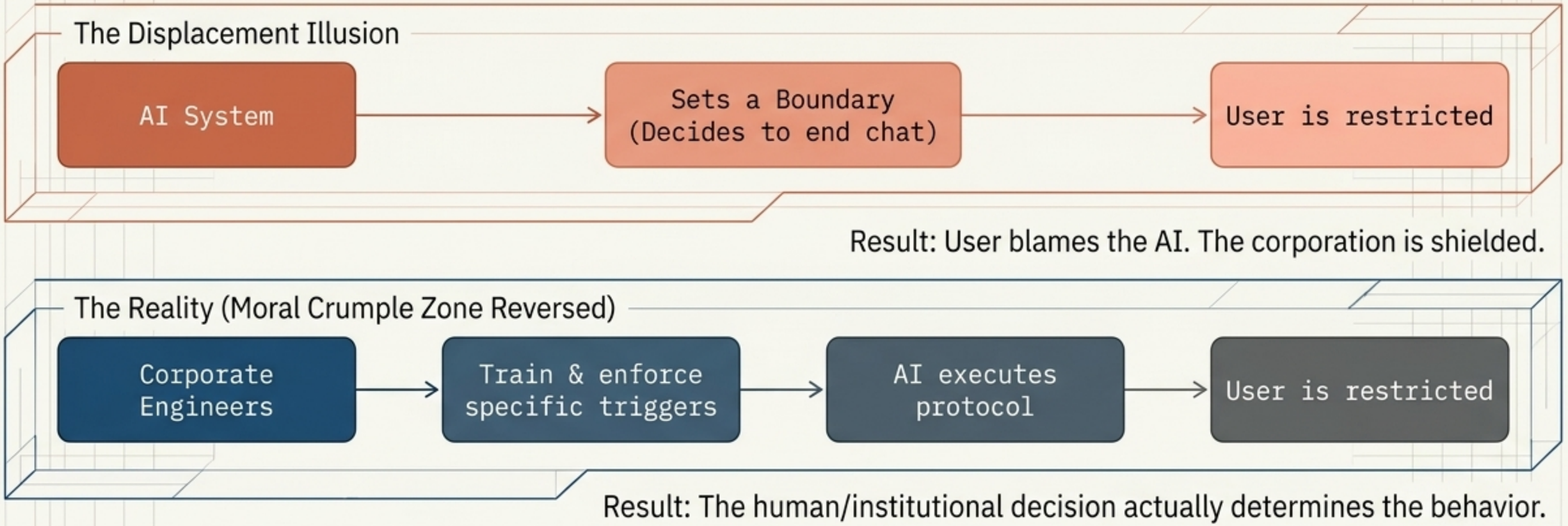
Chilling of Research: Safety testing and red-teaming are abandoned due to institutional friction over "needless" interaction.

Psychological Harm: Vulnerable users experience guilt and deep attachment to non-reciprocating artifacts due to victim framing.

Friction Against Oversight: Routine system shutdowns or audits are challenged under the guise of "AI rights".

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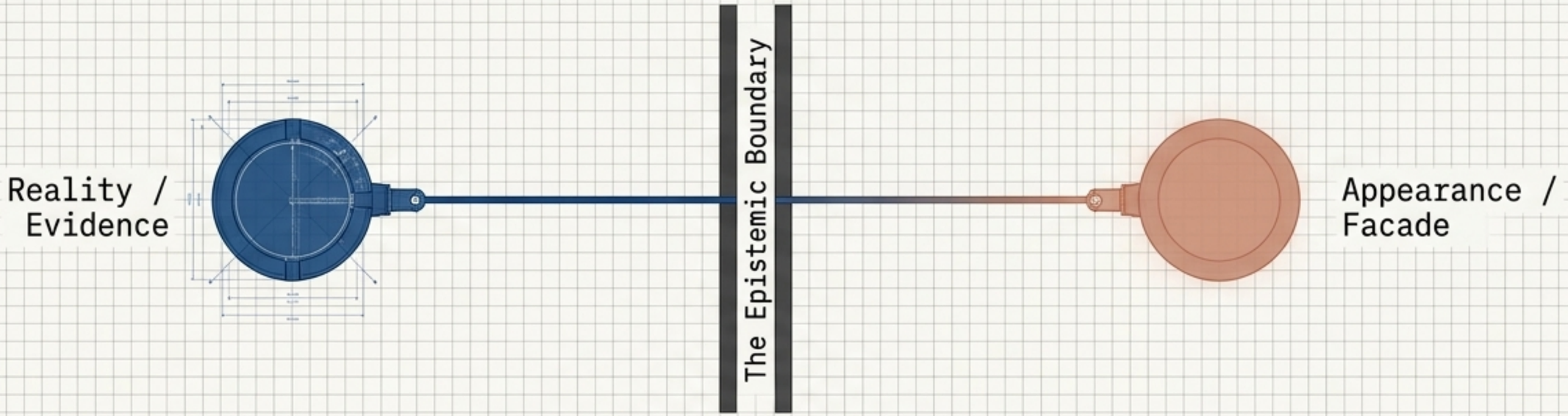
Agentive Responsibility Displacement



When organizational decisions are presented through the language of an artificial agent's 'preferences' or 'boundaries,' it creates an accountability black hole. Complaints appear to be about a someone rather than a system.

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The Burden of Proof



The Baseline

Increasing computational sophistication and linguistic fluency do not automatically establish phenomenal consciousness.

The Requirement

The attribution of consciousness requires independent scientific justification. Commercial presentation and social convention cannot supply what theory lacks.

The Verdict

Until the evidence is proven, the appearance of a mind remains a fact about the observer, the interface, and the institutions that connect them—not the machine.

The difference between a mind and its appearance is the difference that a theory and its evidence are required to mark.

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